

ACCESSIBILITY AUDIT REPORT

Sandusky County Court

sanduskycountycourt.gov · WCAG 2.1 Level AA / ADA Title II

Audit Date: May 2025

Framework: Bootstrap 5

Standard: WCAG 2.1 Level AA

Regulation: ADA Title II

Files Audited: 14 PHP templates

14

FILES
AUDITED

116

FIXES
APPLIED

AA

WCAG
TARGET

Table of Contents

1.	Executive Summary	Page 2
2.	Fix Count by File	Page 2
3.	Shared Templates: head.php, nav.php, foot.php	Page 3
4.	index.php	Page 4
5.	local-rules.php	Page 4
6.	court-appointed-counsel.php	Page 5
7.	audio-request.php	Page 5
8.	forms.php	Page 6
9.	jury-duty.php	Page 6
10.	probation.php	Page 7
11.	judge.php	Page 7
12.	hope-court.php	Page 8
13.	staff.php	Page 8
14.	contact.php	Page 9
15.	Skip Link CSS Fix	Page 9
16.	WCAG Criteria Reference	Page 10

1. Executive Summary



This report documents the WCAG 2.1 Level AA / ADA Title II accessibility audit performed on the **Sandusky County Court** website (sanduskycountycourt.gov). The site is built on **Bootstrap 5**, a modern CSS framework that provides a solid structural foundation but requires additional ARIA instrumentation for full screen-reader compatibility.

The audit covered all 14 PHP templates including three shared includes (head.php, nav.php, foot.php) that propagate fixes to every page. A total of **116 accessibility fixes** were identified and corrected, spanning heading hierarchy, keyboard navigation, ARIA labeling, form accessibility, motion sensitivity, and secure output encoding.

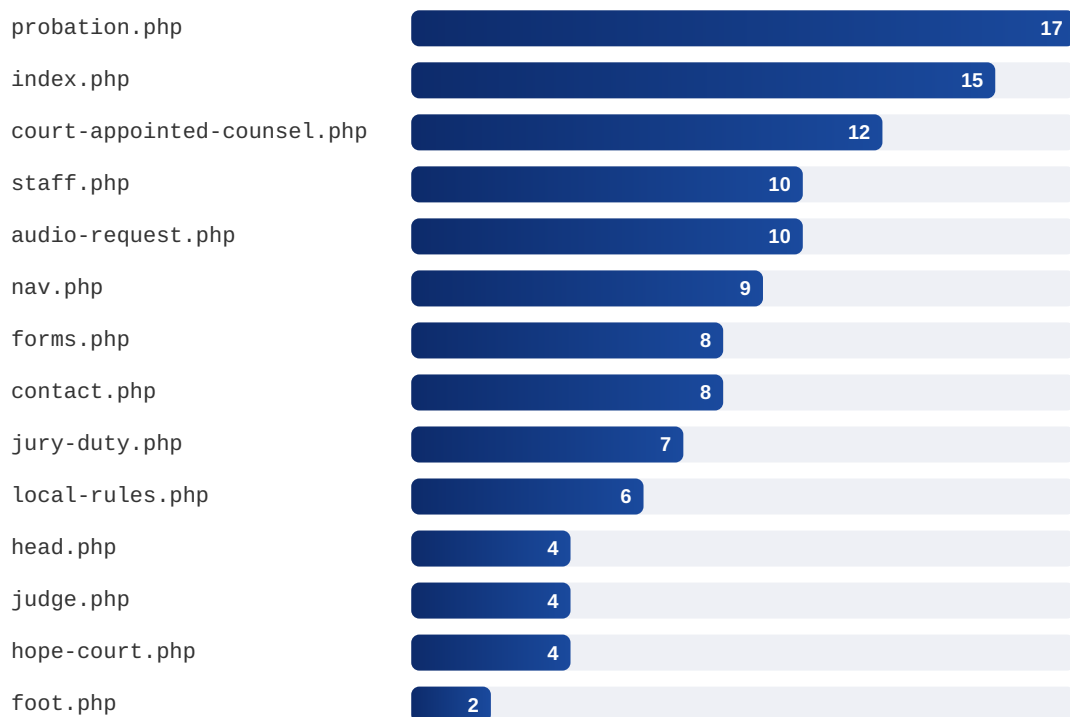
The most impactful single change is the **skip navigation link** added to nav.php, which — combined with `id="main-content"` added to every page's `<main>` element — enables keyboard and screen-reader users to bypass the navigation bar on every page of the site. The skip link is visually hidden until focused, requiring a small CSS addition documented at the end of this report.

Key Issue Categories

Category	Description	Pages Affected
Heading Hierarchy	Bootstrap defaults to <code><h2></code> accordion headers and <code><h5></code> card titles regardless of page context, causing skipped levels. All headings corrected to H1 → H2 → H3 → H4.	11 of 14
Skip Navigation	No skip link existed; added to nav.php. Every page's <code><main></code> was missing <code>id="main-content"</code> .	All pages
ARIA Labels	Navigation landmarks, accordion buttons, modal dialogs, phone links, external links, iframe embeds, and generic buttons all lacked descriptive labels.	11 of 14
Dynamic Page Titles	head.php lacked a dynamic <code><title></code> pattern; several pages had hardcoded duplicate titles or used the wrong <code>\$page_description</code> variable name.	8 of 14

Category	Description	Pages Affected
Form Accessibility	audio-request.php form lacked <code>autocomplete</code> , <code>aria-required</code> , a required-field legend, and used <code>type="text"</code> for a date field.	
Decorative Images	Stock photos carried descriptive alt text that would be announced redundantly by screen readers.	6 of 14
Motion Sensitivity	foot.php's flip-scroll animation had no <code>prefers-reduced-motion</code> guard, risking harm for users with vestibular disorders.	foot.php
Output Encoding	PHP-echoed values (navigation links, form card data, staff data) lacked <code>htmlspecialchars()</code> , creating XSS risk and malformed HTML.	3 of 14

Fix Count by File



2. Shared Templates

These three files are included on every page. Fixes here have site-wide effect.

head.php 4 fixes			
#	Issue	Fix	WCAG
1	Static hardcoded <code><title></code> — all pages shared the same title	Replaced with <code><?=\$page_title ?? 'Sandusky County Court' ?></code>	2.4.2
2	Duplicate static <code><title></code> tag also present	Removed second static title	2.4.2
3	<code>rel="shortcut icon"</code> — deprecated, non-standard	Changed to <code>rel="icon"</code>	Best practice
4	Missing <code>\$page_description</code> fallback	Added null-coalescing fallback for meta description	Best practice

nav.php 9 fixes			
#	Issue	Fix	WCAG
1	No skip navigation link — keyboard users must tab through entire nav on every page	Added <code>Skip to main content</code> as first element	2.4.1
2	Holiday alert <code><div></code> has no live region role	Added <code>role="status"</code>	4.1.3
3	Mobile menu toggle button has no accessible label	Added <code>aria-label="Open navigation menu"</code>	4.1.2
4	Mobile toggle icon not hidden from AT	Added <code>aria-hidden="true"</code> to <code><i></code> icon	1.1.1
5	Desktop <code><nav></code> has no label — indistinguishable from other nav landmarks	Added <code>aria-label="Main navigation"</code>	4.1.2

#	Issue	Fix	WCAG
6	Offcanvas mobile has no label	Added <code>aria-label="Mobile navigation"</code>	4.1.2
7	Active page not indicated to screen readers in either nav	Added <code>aria-current="page"</code> to active link in PHP loop for both desktop and mobile navs	4.1.2
8	"County County" typo in 3 locations	Corrected to "Sandusky County Court" in all 3 locations	Best practice
9	PHP-echoed href values not escaped	Added <code>htmlspecialchars()</code> to all PHP-generated link values	4.1.1

foot.php

2 fixes

#	Issue	Fix	WCAG
1	Flip-scroll card animation runs unconditionally — can trigger vestibular disorders	Added <code>prefers-reduced-motion</code> check in JavaScript: if reduced motion preferred, animation skipped entirely	2.3.3
2	No CSS safety net for reduced-motion	Added <code>@media (prefers-reduced-motion: reduce)</code> block disabling all transitions and locking flip cards static	2.3.3

3. Page-by-Page Findings

index.php			
15 fixes			
#	Issue	Fix	WCAG
1	Hardcoded <code><title></code> tag after head.php include creates duplicate title	Removed hardcoded title; head.php dynamic title used	2.4.2
2	<code><main></code> missing <code>id="main-content"</code> — skip link target broken	Added <code>id="main-content"</code>	2.4.1
3	H1 text reads "Sandusky County County Court" — double word	Corrected to "Sandusky County Court"	Best practice
4	Phone number <code></code> has no accessible label — extension announced ambiguously	Added <code>aria-label="Phone: 419-547-3262 extension 3"</code>	2.4.6
5–14	10 Bootstrap Icons (<code><i class="bi bi-..."></code>) not hidden from assistive technology — announced as unlabeled images	Added <code>aria-hidden="true"</code> to all 10 decorative icons	1.1.1
15	8 department card headings use <code><h5></code> under page <code><h2></code> — skips levels	Changed to <code><h3></code>	1.3.1
—	Featured document "View" / "Download" buttons have no document context	Added descriptive <code>aria-label</code> including document name and action	2.4.6
—	3 FAQ accordion headers use <code><h2 class="accordion-header"></code> under FAQ section <code><h2></code>	Changed to <code><h3 class="accordion-header"></code>	1.3.1

local-rules.php			
6 fixes			
#	Issue	Fix	WCAG
1	Hardcoded duplicate <code><title></code> after head.php include	Removed hardcoded title	2.4.2

#	Issue	Fix	WCAG
2	<code><main></code> missing <code>id="main-content"</code>	Added <code>id="main-content"</code>	2.4.1
3	PDF link opens in new tab with no warning	Added <code>aria-label="Download Local Rules PDF (opens in new tab)"</code>	2.4.4
4– 6	3 accordion headers use <code><h2 class="accordion-header"></code> under section <code><h2></code>	Changed all 3 to <code><h3 class="accordion-header"></code>	1.3.1
7	Stock image has <code>alt="Local Rules"</code> — decorative photo	Changed to <code>alt=""</code>	1.1.1

court-appointed-counsel.php

12 fixes

#	Issue	Fix	WCAG
1	<code>\$page_meta</code> — wrong variable name; head.php reads <code>\$page_description</code>	Changed to <code>\$page_description</code>	2.4.2
2	<code><main></code> missing <code>id="main-content"</code>	Added <code>id="main-content"</code>	2.4.1
3	PDF link opens in new tab with no warning	Added <code>aria-label="Download Financial Disclosure Form PDF (opens in new tab)"</code>	2.4.4
4	Phone link has no accessible label	Added <code>aria-label="Phone: 419-547-3262 extension 3"</code>	2.4.6
5	Stock image <code>alt</code> text describes decorative photo	Changed to <code>alt=""</code>	1.1.1
6–8	3 accordion headers: <code><h2 class="accordion-header"></code> under section <code><h2></code>	Changed to <code><h3></code>	1.3.1
9–11	3 accordion buttons missing <code>aria-expanded</code> and <code>aria-controls</code>	Added <code>aria-expanded="false"</code> and <code>aria-controls</code> to all 3	4.1.2
12	3 accordion panels missing <code>aria-labelledby</code>	Added <code>aria-labelledby</code> pointing to each panel's header id	4.1.2

audio-request.php

10 fixes

#	Issue	Fix	WCAG
1	<code>\$page_meta</code> — wrong variable name	Changed to <code>\$page_description</code>	2.4.2
2	<code>\$page_title</code> format inconsistent	Standardised to 'Audio Request Sandusky County Court'	2.4.2
3	<code><main></code> missing <code>id="main-content"</code>	Added <code>id="main-content"</code>	2.4.1

#	Issue	Fix	WCAG
4	Stock image alt text describes decorative photo	Changed to alt=""	1.1.1
5	Form has required fields but no legend explaining the *	Added Fields marked with * are required. before the form indicator	1.3.1
6–10	All form inputs missing autocomplete attributes and aria-required="true" ; date field uses type="text"	Added autocomplete to all fields (name, tel, email, street-address); added aria-required="true" to required fields; changed date field to type="date"	1.3.5 4.1.2

forms.php

8 fixes

#	Issue	Fix	WCAG
1	<code>\$page_meta</code> — wrong variable name	Changed to <code>\$page_description</code>	2.4.2
2	<code>\$page_title</code> format inconsistent	Standardised to 'Forms Sandusky County Court'	2.4.2
3	<code><main></code> missing <code>id="main-content"</code>	Added <code>id="main-content"</code>	2.4.1
4	Form grid section has no heading — unlabelled landmark region	Added <code><h2 class="visually-hidden">Available Forms</h2></code>	2.4.6
5	PHP echo uses <code><h5></code> for card titles under implicit section — skips levels	Changed PHP echo to output <code><h3 class="card-title"></code>	1.3.1
6	Card images have <code>alt='{\$form['title']}'</code> — duplicates adjacent heading text inside same link	Changed to <code>alt=''</code>	1.1.1
7	Card links open in new tab with no warning	Added <code>aria-label='{\$safe_title} PDF (opens in new tab)'</code>	2.4.4
8	PHP echo values not escaped (<code>\$form['title']</code> , <code>\$form['file']</code> , <code>\$form['img']</code>)	Added <code>htmlspecialchars()</code> via <code>\$safe_*</code> variables	4.1.1

jury-duty.php

7 fixes

#	Issue	Fix	WCAG
1	<code>\$page_meta</code> — wrong variable name	Changed to <code>\$page_description</code>	2.4.2
2	<code>\$page_title</code> format inconsistent	Changed to 'Jury Duty Sandusky County Court'	2.4.2

#	Issue	Fix	WCAG
3	<code><main></code> missing <code>id="main-content"</code>	Added <code>id="main-content"</code>	2.4.1
4	Stock image <code>alt="Jury Duty"</code> — decorative photo	Changed to <code>alt=""</code>	1.1.1
5	Phone link has no accessible label — extension ambiguous	Added <code>aria-label="Phone: 419-547-3262 extension 3"</code>	2.4.6
6	PHP accordion echo uses <code><h2 class='accordion-header'></code> under section <code><h2></code>	Changed to <code><h3 class='accordion-header'></code>	1.3.1
7	PHP accordion echo outputs <code>{ \$question }</code> raw	Added <code>htmlspecialchars(\$question)</code> via <code>\$safe_question</code>	4.1.1

probation.php

17 fixes

#	Issue	Fix	WCAG
1	<code>\$page_meta</code> — wrong variable name	Changed to <code>\$page_description</code>	2.4.2
2	<code>\$page_title</code> format inconsistent	Changed to 'Probation Sandusky County Court'	2.4.2
3	<code><main></code> missing <code>id="main-content"</code>	Added <code>id="main-content"</code>	2.4.1
4	988 ticker duplicate <code></code> for visual loop — all 6 links announced twice by screen readers	Added <code>aria-hidden="true"</code> and <code>tabindex="-1"</code> on all links in the duplicate span	1.3.1
5	988 ticker and figcaption chat links open in new tab with no warning	Added <code>aria-label="Chat online (opens in new tab)"</code>	2.4.4
6	Stock image <code>alt="Probation Services"</code> — decorative photo	Changed to <code>alt=""</code>	1.1.1
7	Officer name headings use <code><h5></code> under <code><h2></code> — skips levels	Changed to <code><h3></code>	1.3.1
8	Officer phone button links have no accessible label	Added <code>aria-label="Phone: 419-547-3262 extension 1" etc.</code>	2.4.6
9	Probation type card titles use <code><h5></code> under <code><h2></code>	Changed to <code><h3></code>	1.3.1
10	Two sections both titled "Probation Services" — duplicate headings confuse heading navigation	Renamed types section to "Types of Probation"	2.4.6
11	988 Lifeline card heading uses <code><h5></code> under <code><h2></code>	Changed to <code><h3></code>	1.3.1

#	Issue	Fix	WCAG
12	Resources document card titles use <code><h5></code> under <code><h2></code>	Changed to <code><h3></code>	1.3.1
13	Generic "View" / "Download" buttons have no document context	Added <code>aria-label="View {title} PDF (opens in new tab)"</code> and <code>"Download {title} PDF"</code>	2.4.6
14	<code>\$item['href']</code> echoed raw in href attribute	Added <code>htmlspecialchars(\$item['href'])</code>	4.1.1
15	3 FAQ accordion headers use <code><h2 class="accordion-header"></code> under section <code><h2></code>	Changed to <code><h3></code>	1.3.1
16	3 FAQ accordion buttons missing <code>aria-expanded</code> and <code>aria-controls</code>	Added both attributes to all 3 buttons	4.1.2
17	3 FAQ accordion panels missing <code>aria-labelledby</code>	Added to all 3 panels	4.1.2

judge.php 4 fixes			
#	Issue	Fix	WCAG
1	<code>\$page_meta</code> — wrong variable name	Changed to <code>\$page_description</code>	2.4.2
2	<code>\$page_title</code> format inconsistent	Changed to <code>'Judge Sandusky County Court'</code>	2.4.2
3	<code><main></code> missing <code>id="main-content"</code>	Added <code>id="main-content"</code>	2.4.1
4	Bio text reads "Sandusky County County Court" — double word, confusing screen reader announcement	Corrected to "Sandusky County Court"	Best practice

Note: The judge's portrait `alt="Judge Cynthia A. Welty"` is intentionally preserved — identifying portraits of real people require descriptive alt text.

hope-court.php 4 fixes			
#	Issue	Fix	WCAG
1	<code>\$page_meta</code> — wrong variable name	Changed to <code>\$page_description</code>	2.4.2
2	<code>\$page_title</code> format inconsistent	Changed to <code>'HOPE Court Sandusky County Court'</code>	2.4.2
3	<code><main></code> missing <code>id="main-content"</code>	Added <code>id="main-content"</code>	2.4.1
4	"Our Purpose" subheading uses <code><h5></code> under <code><h2></code> — skips 2 levels	Changed to <code><h3></code>	1.3.1

Note: HOPE Court logo `alt="HOPE Court Logo"` is intentionally preserved — a program logo is a meaningful, non-decorative image.

staff.php

10 fixes

#	Issue	Fix	WCAG
1	<code>\$page_meta</code> — wrong variable name	Changed to <code>\$page_description</code>	2.4.2
2	<code>\$page_title</code> format inconsistent	Changed to 'Staff Sandusky County Court'	2.4.2
3	<code><main></code> missing <code>id="main-content"</code>	Added <code>id="main-content"</code>	2.4.1
4	Staff grid section has no heading — card <code><h5></code> jumps from H1 to H5	Added <code><h2 class="visually-hidden">Court Staff</h2></code> before grid	1.3.1
5	Card title <code><h5></code> under unlabelled section	Changed to <code><h3></code>	1.3.1
6	Phone links have no <code>aria-label</code> — extension announced separately from link text	Added <code>aria-label="Phone: [number] extension [n]"</code>	2.4.6
7	Generic "Email" buttons — indistinguishable across 6 cards for screen reader users	Added <code>aria-label="Email {name}"</code> to each	2.4.6
8	Generic "Read Bio" buttons — indistinguishable across cards	Added <code>aria-label="Read bio for {name}"</code>	2.4.6
9	Modal title uses <code><h5></code> as primary heading inside <code>role="dialog"</code>	Changed to <code><h2 class="modal-title h5"></code> (semantic H2, visual H5 size preserved)	1.3.1
10	"Sandusky County County Court" typo in 3 staff bio strings	Corrected in Stacy Dickman, Todd Nofzinger, and Alisa Metcalf bios	Best practice

contact.php

8 fixes

#	Issue	Fix	WCAG
1			2.4.2

#	Issue	Fix	WCAG
	<code>\$page_meta</code> — wrong variable name	Changed to <code>\$page_description</code>	
2	<code>\$page_title</code> format inconsistent	Changed to 'Contact Sandusky County Court'	2.4.2
3	<code><main></code> missing <code>id="main-content"</code>	Added <code>id="main-content"</code>	2.4.1
4	Card titles use <code><h5></code> under <code><h2></code> — skips heading levels	Changed to <code><h3></code>	1.3.1
5	Phone/Email/Hours sub-labels use <code><h6></code> under <code><h5></code> (soon H3) — skips to H6	Changed to <code><h4></code>	1.3.1
6	Phone link button has no accessible label — extension ambiguous	Added <code>aria-label="Phone: 419-547-3262 extension 3"</code>	2.4.6
7	Clyde location <code><iframe></code> missing <code>title</code> — screen readers cannot identify embedded map	Added <code>title="Google Maps - Clyde location"</code>	4.1.2
8	Woodville location <code><iframe></code> missing <code>title</code>	Added <code>title="Google Maps - Woodville location"</code>	4.1.2

4. Skip Link CSS (Required)

The skip link added to nav.php is present in the HTML but must be visually hidden by default and revealed on keyboard focus. Add the following CSS to your site stylesheet or inside a `<style>` block in foot.php:

```
.skip-link {
  position: absolute;
  top: -40px;
  left: 0;
  z-index: 9999;
  padding: 8px 16px;
  background: #000;
  color: #fff;
  font-weight: bold;
  text-decoration: none;
  transition: top 0.2s;
}

.skip-link:focus {
  top: 0;
}
```

This keeps the link invisible to sighted mouse users. When a keyboard user presses **Tab** as their first action on any page, the link slides into view at the top of the screen, allowing them to jump directly to the main content area. This satisfies **WCAG 2.4.1 – Bypass Blocks**.

5. WCAG 2.1 Criteria Reference

Criterion	Level	Name	Description
1.1.1	A	Non-text Content	All non-text content has a text alternative. Decorative images use <code>alt=""</code> .
1.3.1	A	Info and Relationships	Structure, relationships, and headings are conveyed programmatically. Heading hierarchy must not skip levels.
1.3.5	AA	Identify Input Purpose	Form inputs that collect personal data expose <code>autocomplete</code> attributes matching the input's purpose.
2.3.3	AAA	Animation from Interactions	Motion animation triggered by interaction can be disabled. Sites should respect <code>prefers-reduced-motion</code> .
2.4.1	A	Bypass Blocks	A mechanism exists to skip repeated navigation blocks (e.g., skip link).
2.4.2	A	Page Titled	Each page has a title that describes its topic or purpose.
2.4.4	A	Link Purpose (In Context)	The purpose of each link can be determined from the link text or context. New-tab links must warn users.
2.4.6	AA	Headings and Labels	Headings and labels describe topic or purpose. Generic labels like "View" or "Email" need additional context.
4.1.1	A	Parsing	HTML is well-formed; elements are properly nested. PHP output must be encoded with <code>htmlspecialchars()</code> .
4.1.2	A	Name, Role, Value	All UI components have accessible names, roles, and state values exposed to assistive technology.
4.1.3	AA	Status Messages	Status messages are announced without requiring focus (e.g., <code>role="status"</code> on alert regions).

Sandusky County Court — Accessibility Audit Report

sanduskycourt.gov · WCAG 2.1 Level AA / ADA Title II · 14 files · 116 fixes · May 2025